PART III · EXPRESSION · 4

The pedals

Most pianos have three pedals. The right one, the **sustain pedal**, lifts every damper off the strings, so notes keep ringing after your fingers let go. The left one makes the sound softer.

THE SECRET

Play first, then change the pedal: up and straight down again.



soft pedal
una corda
softer, gentler

middle pedal
sostenuto
holds only some notes

sustain pedal
damper pedal
notes keep ringing

Right pedal: the notes keep ringing

PEDAL	NAME AND SIGN	WHAT IT DOES
left	soft pedal: *una corda*, written *u.c.*	a softer, gentler sound; lift it at *t.c.* (*tre corde*)
middle	*sostenuto* *Extra*	holds only the notes already down (on many uprights: a practice mute)
right	sustain (damper) pedal: *Ped.*	every note keeps ringing until you lift it

Writing the sustain pedal

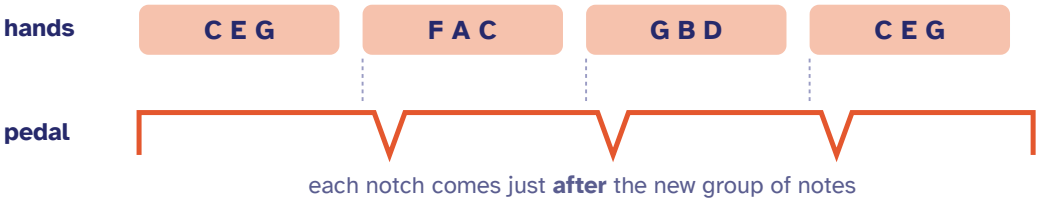


THE RULE

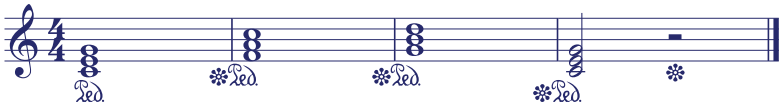
Heel on the floor, press with the ball of your foot. Play first, then pedal: new notes, then up and straight down again.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 4 · CONTINUED

Changing the pedal



each notch comes just **after** the new group of notes



A chord is three or more notes played together. The ✻Ped. sits under each new chord: play it first, then change straight away.
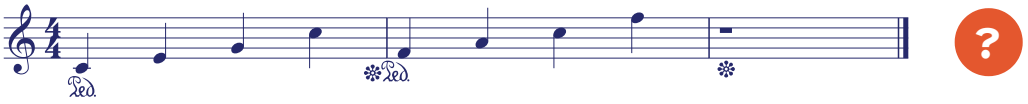
EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Half pedal and the middle pedal

Half pedal: lift the pedal only part of the way, to clear some of the sound but not all. **Sostenuto** (the middle pedal on grand pianos): press it while notes are held, and only those notes keep ringing.

EXAMPLE 1

Where does the pedal go down, and where does it come up?
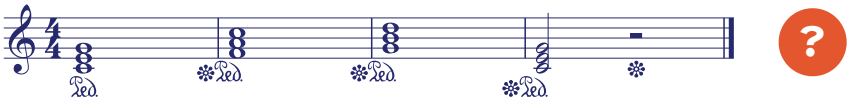


1. **Find Ped.** under the first C.
2. **Find the next sign:** a star with Ped.
3. **Find the last star.**

Down on the first C, **changed** at the first F (up and down again), and up at the end: each bar rings as one sound.

EXAMPLE 2

Why change at every new chord?



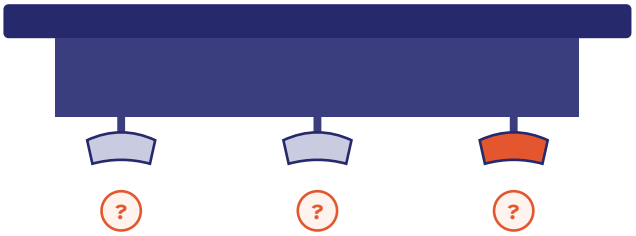
1. **Hold the pedal** from C-E-G into F-A-C. What do you hear?
2. **Now change** just after the F.
3. **Compare** the two.

Without a change, the two groups **blur** into a muddle. Change on each new chord: clean, and still joined.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Which pedal?



1 **Ped.**: which foot pedal? 2 **u.c.**: which one? 3 **t.c.**: what do you do?

Ped. is the **right** pedal; *u.c.* the **left** one; *t.c.* means let the left pedal up.

GAME
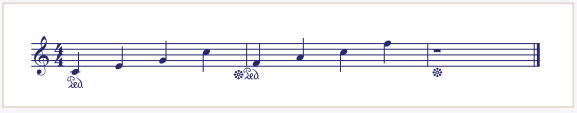
Up or down?

1	2	3	4
Ped.	*	u.c.	t.c.

Which pedal, and up or down?

Answer: 1 right pedal down · 2 right pedal up · 3 left pedal down · 4 left pedal up.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hear the ringing.

Play C, E and G together, press the right pedal and take your hands off: the chord keeps sounding. Lift the pedal: silence.

HOW TO

Practise the pedal change

1. **Without playing**, say “play, up-down” and move your foot on “up-down”.
2. **Play C-E-G, then F-A-C, then G-B-D**, slowly. Change just after each one.
3. **Listen** for a clean change with no gap of silence.

THINK OF IT The sustain pedal holds a door open: every note that walks in stays in the room until you let the door shut.

TRAP

- × Lifting the pedal before the new notes: a gap of silence. Play first, then change.
- × Keeping the pedal down through a new chord: muddy.

SEE ALSO
Touch p. 76 · Chords p. 107

PRACTISE IT
Online: Library › Pedal